



The Tenth Watch

This is the official website for watching the 10th drop in the Pitch Drop Experiment. Only 14 or so years to go... <https://digit.in/mar20-11>

meh.

Bells are ringing

In this video, you can hear the famous Oxford Bell in action. Or not... the ringing is deplorably faint. <https://digit.in/mar20-12>

Longest running Experiments

These experiments have been going on for decades, and there are no real plans to stop them any time soon.

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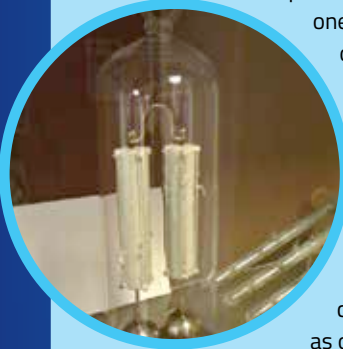
Oxford Bell

Running since 1840

University of Oxford, England

A physics professor at the University of Oxford was provided an interesting little device manufactured by a London firm called Watkins and Hill. It was a battery that made a hanging metal ball oscillate between two bells. The movement of the metal ball is powered by a dry pile battery, one of the earliest forms of energy storage ever invented. That battery has continued to last for almost two centuries, while our smartphones struggle to get through a day. No one really knows the exact composition of the battery, as opening it up to see what is inside could ruin the experiment.

The apparatus has been working continuously since the mid 1800s, and scientists have calculated that they bells have sounded over a billion times.



Vesuvius Observatory

Running since 1841

Naples, Italy

The facility was originally founded by Ferdinand II of Bourbon, and is the oldest volcanology institute in the world. It was originally set up with the specific goal of monitoring Mt Vesuvius, and to give an advanced warning if there were signs of an imminent eruption. The first director of the facility, Macedonio Melloni wanted to locate the facility elsewhere because of the interference that the magnetic lava flows caused to the sensitive instruments. Now, the facility monitors other volcanoes in Campi Flegrei and Ischia as well. All of these are active volcanoes. At the original facility, there remains a museum, a library and some laboratories. Scientists have observed the erupting volcano from the observatory, even though it was dangerous.



The 500 year microbiology experiment

A team of international scientists wanted to figure out exactly how long dormant microbes remain viable, and can come back to life. In 2014, they started an experiment that is scheduled to run for 500 years, with microbes revitalised periodically from sealed jars. Now, the question really is, how the scientists plan to maintain records for the planned 500 years run time of the experiment. They are using the low tech but reliable archival quality pen and paper.